Alexandra **To**

Assistant Professor · Northeastern University

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Google Scholar Profile

Employment

Northeastern University

Boston, MA

Assistant Professor — *August 2020 - PRESENT*

Jointly appointed in the Art + Design department (Games) in the College of Arts, Media, & Design (50%) and the Khoury College of Computer Sciences (50%)

Education

Carnegie Mellon University

Pittsburgh, PA

PhD in Human-Computer Interaction — *Aug. 2015 - Jul. 2020*

- Human Computer Interaction Institute | School of Computer Science
- Thesis: "*Empowering Uncertainty Resolution for Marginalized Populations through Social Technology*"
- Advisors: Jessica Hammer and Geoff Kaufman
- Committee: Kevin Jarbo, Kody Manke, Jason Hong

Stanford University

Stanford, CA

B.S. in Symbolic Systems, HCI Concentration, Minor in Asian American Studies — *Sept. 2010 - Jun. 2015*

M.S. in Symbolic Systems

- Symbolic Systems Program | School of Humanities and Sciences
- Honors Thesis: "*Foundry: Managing Teams of Experts Online*"
- Masters Thesis: "*Experts On Demand: Enabling Flash Organizations with Rapid Onboarding*"
- Advisor: Michael Bernstein

Honors & Awards

2025 **Honorable Mention Paper Award**, ACM CHI PLAY (top 5%)
Honorable Mention Paper Award, ACM CHI (top 5%)

2024 **Faculty Early Career Development Program (CAREER) Awardee**, National Science Foundation
Best Paper Award, ACM FDG (top 1%)

2023 **Best Paper Award**, ACM DIS (top 1%)
Honourable Mention Paper Award, ACM CHI (top 5%)
CAMD Summer Grant Writing Fellowship, Northeastern University

2021 **Honourable Mention Paper Award**, ACM CHI (top 5%)

2020 **Award Recognizing Contribution to Diversity & Inclusion**, ACM CSCW
Best Paper Award, ACM CSCW (top 1%)
Best Paper Award, ACM CHI (top 1%)

2018 **Graduate Student Small Project Funding Award ($750)**, CMU GSA / Vice Provost's Office

2017 **Best Paper Award**, ACM CHI 2017 (top 1%)
University/Post-Secondary Student Honorable Mention, Carnegie Science Awards

2016 **Best Student Non-Digital Game, "Outbreak"**, Meaningful Play 2016
People's Choice Game, "Outbreak", Meaningful Play 2016
Graduate Student Assembly/Provost Conference Funds, Carnegie Mellon University

2014 **Best Paper Award**, ACM UIST (top 1%)
B.S. Conferred with Honors, Stanford University

Scholarship: Reviewed Articles

Note: In HCI, co-authorship is extremely common. First-authorship tends to go towards lead junior scholar (e.g., lead PhD student), last author tends to indicate lead senior scholar (e.g.,

advising faculty).

39. [IN PRESS] Williams, G., Rusagara, S., **To, A.**, *What do you mean by "Hood" Prom?: Joyful Narratives Shown Through The Eyes of Black Teens on TikTok*.

38. Smith, A.D.R., Williams, G., Thompson, G., **To, A.**, *Constructing a Community of Play: Black Sims Players and Game Modding*. In the Proceedings of the Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play (CHI PLAY) 2025. **Honorable Mention Award**

37. Wu, Y., **To, A.**, Rader, E., Edwards, K., Das, S. *Provoking Transformation in Usable Privacy and Security: Designing for Enduring End-User Motivation Beyond Expert Compliance*. In the Proceedings of the New Security Paradigms Workshop (NSPW) 2025.

36. Zabala, J., Zvelebilova, J., **To, A.**, *"I felt like I was them. I just didn't know it.": Exploring Queer Identity through TTRPG Play*. In Proceedings of the Digital Games Research Association (DiGRA) 2025.

35. Williams, G., Chen, N., DeVito, M.A., **To, A.**, *Why Can't Black Women Just Be?: Black Femme Content Creators Navigating Algorithmic Monoliths*. In. Proc. CHI 2025. **Honorable Mention Award**

34. [Turay, B.M., Baca Vázquez, A.]*, **To, A.**, Smith, A.D.R., *"I want to let them in": Exploring Critical Consciousness Development through Roleplay and Reflection in Papers, Please*. In Proceedings of the International Conference on the Foundations of Digital Games (FDG) 2025.

33. Lee, C., Delandro, D., Zabala, J., **To, A.**, *Designing Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy for BIPOC Youth through an Ecological Justice Transformational Game*. In. Proc. AERA 2025.

32. Showkat, D., Chan, L., Brooks, C., Raithatha, D., **To, A.**, *Cultivating Community and Creating Safe Spaces: Exploring A Design Toolkit for the Learned Values of Students of Color*. [IN PRESS] In Proceedings of the ACM SIGCHI Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work & Social Computing (CSCW) 2025.

31. Showkat, D., Wang, L., Chan, L., **To, A.**, *Equality Engine: Fostering Critical Machine Learning Bias Literacy Through a Transformational Game*. [IN PRESS] In Proceedings of the ACM SIGCHI Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work & Social Computing (CSCW) 2025.

30. Williams, G., De Los Santos, M., **To, A.**, Savage, S., *Mapping the Crowdsourcing Workforce in Latin America and the Caribbean*. In. Proc. MexIHC 2024.

29. Zabala, J., Zvelebilova, J., **To, A.**, *Queer TTRPGs' Visibility, Safety, and Allegory as Resistance*. In Proceedings of the International Conference on the Foundations of Digital Games (FDG) 2024. **Best Paper Award**

28. Chan, L., Showkat, D., **To, A.**, *An Exploration of Learned Values Through Lived Experiences to Design for BIPOC Students' Flourishing*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2024 Late-Breaking Work.

27. Carey, H., **To, A.** (2024). *"Lots of extra time and privilege to just dream of utopia": Understanding barriers to long-term visioning in racial justice work*. In Journal of Future Studies, Vol. 28(3).

26. [**To, A.**, Smith, A.D.R.]*, Showkat, D., Adjagbodjou, A., Harrington, C. *Flourishing in the Everyday: Moving Beyond Damage-Centered Design in HCI for BIPOC Communities*. In Proc. DIS 2023. **Best Paper Award**
*First two authors contributed equally

25. Zabala, J., Zvelebilova, J., **To, A.** (2023). *Safety and Identity Exploration: How Queer TTRPGs Provide Structure for Players*. In Proceedings of the Digital Games Research Association (DiGRA) 2023 Extended Abstracts.

24. Showkat, D., Smith, A.D.R., Wang, L., **To, A.**. *"Who is the right homeless client?": Values in Algorithmic Homelessness Service Provision and Machine Learning Research*. In. Proc. ACM (CHI) Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2023.

23. Chen, Y., Smith, A.D.R., Reinecke, K., **To, A.**. *Why, when, and from whom: considerations for collecting and reporting race and ethnicity data in HCI*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2023. **Honorable Mention Award** 🎖

22. Hantsbarger, M., Troiano, G., **To, A.**, Harteveld, C. *Alienated Serendipity and Reflective Failure: Exploring Queer Game Mechanics and Queerness in Games via Queer Temporality*. In Proceedings of the Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play (CHI PLAY) 2022.

21. Chen, Y. T., Smith, A.D.R., Reinecke, K., **To, A.**, *Collecting and Reporting Race and Ethnicity Data in HCI: Who and Why?*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2022 Late-Breaking Work.

20. **To, A.**, Carey, H., Shrivastava, R., Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. *Interactive Fiction Provotypes for Coping with Interpersonal Racism*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing 2022.

19. Brooks, C., Principe Cruz, E., Camera, J., **To, A.** *Uplifting Us: A BIPOC Game Design Case Study*. In Proceedings of the International Conference on Foundations of Digital Games (FDG) 2021 -Breaking Work.

18. Bennett, C. L., Gleason, C., Klaus Scheuerman, M., Bigham, J. P., Guo, A., **To, A.** *"It's Complicated": Negotiating Accessibility and (Mis)Representation in Image Descriptions of Race, Gender, and Disability*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2021.
Honorable Mention Award 🎖

17. **To, A.**, Carey, H., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. *Reducing Uncertainty and Offering Comfort: Designing Technology for Coping with Interpersonal Racism*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2021

16. Carey, H., **To, A.**, Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. *Fictional, Interactive Narrative as a Foundation to Talk about Racism*. In Proc. ACM Designing Interactive Systems (DIS) 2020 Work-in-Progress.

15. **To, A.**, Sweeney, W., Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. *"They Just Don't Get It": Towards Social Technologies for Coping with Interpersonal Racism*. In Proceedings of the ACM Conference On Computer-Supported Cooperative Work & Social Computing (CSCW) 2020.
Best Paper Award 🏆**, Award Recognizing Contribution to D&I** 🏆

14. [**To, A.**, Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, I.F., Smith, A.]*, Toyama, K. *Critical Race Theory for HCI*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2020.
Best Paper Award 🏆
*First three authors contributed equally

13. Holmes, J., **To, A.**, Zhang, F., Park, S.E., Ali, S., Bai, Z., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. (2019). *A Good Scare: Leveraging Game Theming and Narrative to Impact Player Experience*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2019 Late-Breaking Work.

12. Fath, E., **To, A.**, Kaufman, G., Hammer, J., (2018). *Designing an Inclusive Playtesting Process Using Cognitive Load Theory*. In Proc. Meaningful Play 2018

11. Ali, S., **To, A.**, Bai, Z., Holmes, J., Fath, E., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. (2018). *Transition from Goal Driven Game Design to Game Driven Goal Delineation in Tandem Transformational Game Design*. In Proceedings of the International Conference on Meaningful Play 2018.

10. **To, A.**, Holmes, J., Fath, E., Zhang, E., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. (2017). *Modeling and Designing for Key Elements of Curiosity: Risking Failure, Valuing Questions*. In Proceedings of the Digital Games Research Association (DiGRA) International Conference 2017.

9. **To, A.**, Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. (2017). *Character Diversity in Digital and Non-Digital Games*. In Proceedings of the Digital Games Research Association (DiGRA) 2017 Gaming the Systems: Towards a More Inclusive DiGRA Workshop.

8. **To, A.**, Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. (2017). *Scaffolding Conversation through the Design and Implementation of Board Games*. In Proceedings of the Digital Games Research Association (DiGRA) 2017 Boardgame Studies Round Table Workshop.

7. Valentine, M., Retelny, D., **To, A.**, Rahmati, N., Doshi, T., Bernstein, M. (2017). *Flash Organizations: Crowdsourcing Complex Work by Structuring Crowds as Organizations*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2017. **Best Paper Award**

6. **To, A.**, Fath, E., Zhang, E., Ali, S., Kildunne, C., Fan, A., Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. (2016). *Tandem Transformational Game Design: A Game Design Process Case Study*. In Proc. Meaningful Play 2016.

5. **To, A.**, Fan, A., Kildunne, C., Zhang, E., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. (2016). *Treehouse Dreams: A Game-Based Method for Eliciting Interview Data from Children*. In Proceedings of the Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play (CHI PLAY) Work-in-Progress 2016.

4. **To, A.**, Ali, S., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. (2016). *Integrating Curiosity and Uncertainty in Game Design*. In Proceedings of DiGRA/FDG 2016.

3. Nebeling, M., **To, A.**, Guo, A., de Freitas, A., Teevan, J., Dow, S., Bigham, J. (2016). *WearWrite: Crowd-Assisted Writing from Smartwatches*. In Proceedings of the ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2016.

2. Retelny, D., Robaszkiewicz, S., **To, A.**, Lasecki, W., Patel, J., Doshi, T., Valentine, M., Bernstein, M. (2014). *Expert Crowdsourcing with Flash Teams*. In Proc. UIST '14. **Best Paper Award**

1. Retelny, D., Robaszkiewicz, S., **To, A.**, Bernstein, M. (2013). *Enabling Expert Crowdsourcing with Flash Teams*. In Proc. CrowdConf 2013.

Scholarship: Non-Reviewed / Invited Articles

5. Race in HCI Collective, Smith, A.D.R., Alvarado Garcia, A., Arawjo, I., Bennett, A., Braswell, K., Dosono, B., Eglash, R., Ford, D., Gardner, D., Goddard, S., Nias, J., Passmore, C., Rankin, Y., Rizvi, N., Scott, C.F., Thomas, J., **To, A.**, Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, I.F., & Wong-Villacres, M. (2021). *"Keepin' it real about race in HCI"*. Interactions, Vol. 28, No. 5, 28-33.

4. Thomas, J. O., Kumar, N., **To, A.**, Brown, Q., & Rankin, Y. A. (2021). *"Discovering intersectionality: part 2: reclaiming our time"*. Interactions, Vol. 28, No. 4, 72-75.

3. Brown, Q., Kumar, N., Thomas, J., **To, A.**, Rankin, Y. (2021) *"Discovering intersectionality part I: researcher interrupted"*. *Interactions, Vol. 28, No. 3*

2. **To, A.**, McDonald, J., Holmes, J., Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. (2018). *Character Diversity in Digital and Non-Digital Games*. In Proceedings of Transactions of the Digital Games Research Association (ToDiGRA) Diversity Special Issue, Vol 4.1

1. **To, A.**, Holmes, J., Fath, E., Zhang, E., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. (2018). *Modeling and Designing for Key Elements of Curiosity: Risking Failure, Valuing Questions*. In Proceedings of Transactions of the Digital Games Research Association (ToDiGRA) Special Issue, Selected Papers from DiGRA 2017, Vol 4.2

Scholarship: Book Chapters

3. Fath, E., Hammer, J., **To, A.** (2024). *"Outbreak"*. *Learning, Education, & Games: Volume 4. 50 Games for Inclusion, Equity, and Justice.* ETC Press.

2. Smith, A.D.R., Williams, I.F., **To, A.** (2021). *"Racial Justice and Scholar-Activism"*. *Networked Feminisms: Activist Assemblies and Digital Practices.* Lexington Books.

1. Hammer, J., **To, A.**, Schrier, K., Bowman, S.L., Kaufman, G. (2018). *"Learning and Role-Playing Games". Role-Playing Game Studies: Transmedia Foundations.* Routledge.

Scholarship: Other Publications

WORKSHOPS, SIGS, PANELS, & WORKSHOP PAPERS

13. Wu, Y., Palacios Abad, B., Sharma, V., Li, H., **To, A.**, *Alternative Technology Consumption Under Capitalism*. In Proc. CSCW 2025 SIGs.

12. Williams, G., **To, A.**, *Resisting AI Solutionism*. In Proc. CHI 2025 Workshop Resisting AI Solutionism: Where Do We Go From Here?

11. Kim, J., Popowski, L., Fang, A., Pyle, C., Freeman, G., Kelly, R.M., Lee, A.Y., Liu, F., Smith, A.D.R., **To, A.**, Zhang, A. *Envisioning New Futures of Positive Social Technology: Beyond Paradigms of Fixing, Protecting, and Preventing*. In CSCW 2024 Workshops.

10. Hammer, J., **To, A.**, Principe Cruz, E. *Creating Countercultures in Game Research.* In Proceedings of the Conference on Meaningful Play 2022.

9. Showkat, D., Bellamy, S.. **To, A.**, *Fair and Trustworthy Welfare Systems: Rethinking Explainable AI in the Public Sector*. In Proceedings of the CHI 2022 Workshop Human-Centered Explainable AI (HCXAI).

8. Liang, C.A., Tseng, E., Pendse, S., Lee, C., Allison, K.R., Tan, N.H., Wang, R., **To, A.**, Zhang, A. *Subtle CSCW Traits: Tensions Around Identity Formation and Online Activism in the Asian Diaspora*. In CSCW 2021 Workshops [*organized virtually*].

7. Smith, A., Ahmed, A., Alvarado Garcia, A., Dosono, B., Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, I., Rankin, Y., **To, A.**, Toyama, K. *What's Race Got to Do With It? Engaging in Race in HCI*. In CHI 2020 Workshops [*organized virtually*].

6. **To, A.**, Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. *The Role of Trust in Technology in Coping with Experiences with Racism*. In Proc. CSCW 2019 Social Technologies for Digital Wellbeing Among Marginalized Communities Workshop.

5. **To, A.**, Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. *Mitigating Vicarious Trauma in Conducting Sensitive Research.* In Proc. CHI 2019 Sensitive Research, Practice, and Design in HCI Workshop.

4. **To, A.**, Hammer, J., Kaufman, G. *Promoting Digital Wellbeing by Empowering Users from Racial Minority Groups*. In Proc. CHI 2019 Designing for Digital Wellbeing Workshop.

3. Deterding, S., Smith, D., Powley, E.J., Hammer, J., **To, A.**, Guckelsberger, C. 2018. *Curiosity in Games: An Interdisciplinary Workshop*. In Proc. FDG 2018 Workshops.

2. **To, A.**, Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. 2017. *Designing Affective Supports for Curiosity in Games*. In Proc. CHI 2017 Designing for Curiosity Workshop.

1. Nebeling, M., **To, A.**, Guo, A., de Freitas, A., Teevan, J., Dow, S., Bigham, J. 2016. *WearWrite: Crowd-Assisted Writing from Smartwatches.* In Proc. CHI 2016 Productivity Decomposed Workshop.

MISCELLANEOUS (DEMOS, POSTERS, ALT.CHI, GAMES, AND THESES)

7. Asibey, D., **To, A.**, 2022. *"They Didn't Mean That."* Presented at the 53rd annual international conference of the International Simulation and Gaming Association (ISAGA) Game Demos.

6. **To, A.**, 2020. *Empowering Uncertainty Resolution for Marginalized Populations through Social Technology*. PhD Thesis, Human-Computer Interaction Institute. Committee: Jessica Hammer, Geoff Kaufman, Kevin Jarbo, Jason Hong, Kody Manke

5. Hammer, J., **To, A.**, Principe Cruz, E. *Lab Counterculture.* In CHI 2020 alt.CHI.

4. **To, A.**, Ali, S., Kaufman, G., Hammer, J. *Integrating Curiosity and Uncertainty in Game Design*. 2018 Curiosity Research in HCI.

3. Nebeling, M., Guo, A., **To, A.**, Dow, S., Teevan, J., Bigham, J. 2015. *WearWrite: Orchestrating the Crowd to Complete Complex Tasks from Wearables*. In Proc. UIST 2015 Demos.

2. **To, A.**. 2015. *Experts On Demand: Enabling Flash Organizations with Rapid Onboarding*. Masters Thesis, Symbolic Systems Program. Readers: Michael Bernstein, Melissa Valentine

1. **To, A.**. 2014. *Foundry: Managing Teams of Experts Online*. Senior Honors Thesis, Symbolic Systems Program. Readers: Michael Bernstein, Daniela Retelny

Creative Activity: Game Design Projects

Note: These are complete, playable games I have designed both as creative activity and to be used in my research.

"*Untitled Ghost Game*" - Designed with Brandon Sichling, Jailyn Zabala *2025-PRESENT*
A TTRPG focused on processing feels of guilt and shame towards rage and action in the face of existential threats.

"*The Discovered Country*" - Designed with Brandon Sichling, Jailyn Zabala *2024-2025*
A non-digital collaborative world-building game designed for social justice advocates to temporarily set aside the present to envision the long-term future. Link to Itch.io Site.

"*The Conversation Game*" - Designed with Michael Arnold Mages *2021-2022*
Adaptation of Michael Arnold Mages' tabletop card game for online synchronous play developed in Unity. The Conversation Game encourages reflective practice to facilitate difficult conversations.

"*myPWI*" - Designed with Chris Brooks, Jamie Camera *2020-2022*
Adventure RPG prototype developed in Unity that addresses the experiences of students of color at predominantly white institutions.

"*They Didn't Mean That*" - Foundational Fiction *2018-2022*
Twine Interactive fiction about racial microaggressions. Primer to facilitate generative conversations about coping with racism in follow-up design workshops as well as tool for prototyping and allowing people to use and critique speculative future technologies for coping with racism.

"Outbreak" - Designed with Elaine Fath *2015 - 2018*
Tabletop game that encourages curiosity as a skill set to increase comfort with STEM for underrepresented adolescents (women and/or BIPOC students). Link to GameCrafter Site.

Scholarship: Invited Presentations & Events

INVITED WORKSHOPS

CRA Computing Community Consortium (CCC) *12/2024*
"Supporting At-Risk Users through Responsible Computing" Workshop

KEYNOTES, TALKS, & PANELS

Northeastern Critical Science and Technology Studies Working Group *06/2025*
"Academic Freedom & Research Ethics: Context and Perspectives" Panel

Northeastern "Runway to Broader Impacts" Series *05/2025*
"Strategizing Broader Impacts"

Women of Color in the Academy (WOCIA) Conference *05/2025*
"Digital Hygiene: Balancing Visibility, Safety, Authenticity, and Community in Trying Times" -
Co-Presented with Michael Ann DeVito and Andrea Stith

Northeastern "Mental Health Matters" Series *03/2025*
"Rebelling Against Dark Patterns in Academia through Community and Counterculture"

Northeastern CAMD "Food for Thought" *03/2025*
"Transformational Play & Scholar-Activism"

Game Devs of Color Expo *09/2024*
"Critical Race Theory for Game Designers"

Northeastern Asian American Conference *01/2024*
"Telling Meaningful Stories through Games"

Harvard CompSci 79 Guest Lecture *11/2023*
"Game Prototyping and Playtesting for HCI"

Khoury Graduate Program Workshop Series *10/2023*
"Reading Research Papers Like a Scientist" Panel

2022 New England Future Faculty Workshop *07/2022*
"Developing a Quick Start Plan: STEM" Panel

Wellesley @ Khoury *07/2022*
"The Value of Research"

Hertz Foundation Summer Workshop: STEM Inclusivity *07/2022*
"Fostering Diversity and Inclusion through Lab Counterculture"

Khoury Apprenticeship Research Showcase Keynote *04/2022*
"The Value of Research"

CHI 2022 QTBIPOC Participatory Design Workshop Lightning Talk *04/2022*
"Racial Justice and Scholar-Activism in HCI"

Scout Northeastern "Interventions: Amplify" Conference *04/2022*
"Design Justice" Moderated Discussion with Sasha Costanza-Chock

KTH Royal Institute of Technology Interaction Design FFF Seminar *04/2022*
"*Uplifting Us: Design Opportunities in Centering Racialized Experiences in Games*"

Pittsburgh Racial Justice Summit *01/2022*
"*Processing Secondhand Trauma*"

MIT Comparative Media Studies Colloquium Series *12/2021*
"*Uplifting Us: Design Opportunities in Centering Racialized Experiences in Games*"

Methods, Theories, and Taking Action through Gender and Feminisms in Human-Computer Interaction Keynote *09/2021*
"*Empowerment and Intersectional Feminism in HCI*"

Twitch "Games, Communities, and Society" Speaker Series *05/2021*
"*Exploring Game Design for BIPOC Joy and Empowerment*"

Northeastern University Center for Design Conversation Series *04/2021*
"*Rethinking Design Thinking in the Pluriverse*" Talk & Panel Discussion

UConn CSE Diversity & Inclusion Talk *04/2021*
"*Designing to Empower Marginalized Communities through Social Technology*"

Northeastern University Art+Design Faculty DEIB Workshop *04/2021*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI (And Art + Design)*"

University of Minnesota CSci 8115 Guest Lecture *03/2021*
"*Qualitative Research - Interview Method Tips*"

MIT CSAIL HCI Seminar *03/2021*
"*Designing to Empower Marginalized Communities through Social Technology*"

DePaul University HCD 450 Guest Lecture *02/2021*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" & "*Reducing Uncertainty and Offering Comfort: Designing Technology for Coping with Interpersonal Racism*"

University of British Columbia Designing for People (DFP@UBC) Seminar *02/2021*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Microsoft Research Cambridge HCI Community Talk *02/2021*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Angela Smith

Indiana University Informatics Colloqium Series *01/2021*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Pittsburgh Racial Justice Summit *01/2021*
"*Critical Race Theory and Technology*"

University of Washington DUB Seminar *01/2021*
"*Designing to Empower Marginalized Communities through Social Technology*"

Northeastern University - Khoury College *12/2020*
"*Coded Bias Viewing & Panel Discussion*"

Stanford HCI Seminar *10/2020*
"*Designing to Empower Marginalized Communities through Social Technology*"

Cornell Info Sci Colloqium *10/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Wellesley CS220 HCI Guest Lecture *09/2020*
"*Designing to Empower Marginalized Communities through Social Technology*" & "*Critical Race Theory for HCI*"

UChicago HCI Seminar *08/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

University of Maryland HCIL *08/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Snap HCI Research Special Seminar *08/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

UC Berkeley AFOG Group *08/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

ChicagoCHI *08/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Adobe Research HCI/VIS Seminar *08/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Thumbtack DEI, Design, Research Special Seminar *07/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

University of Michigan MISC Seminar *07/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Facebook *07/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Stanford University HCI Group Lunch Seminar *07/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Carnegie Mellon HCII and Robotics Institute Special Seminar *07/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

University of Washington DUB Seminar *07/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Northeastern University - Khoury College of Computer Sciences *06/2020*
"*Designing to Empower Marginalized Communities through Social Technology*"

Microsoft Research HCI Seminar *05/2020*
"*Critical Race Theory for HCI*" - Co-Presented with Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu, Angela Smith

Innovation with Impact, Carnegie Mellon University *04/2020*
"Fictional, Interactive Narrative as a Foundation to Talk about Racism"

Women in Data Science (WiDs) @ CMU *03/2020*
Virtual Panel

Northeastern University - College of Arts, Media & Design *02/2020*
"*Designing to Empower Marginalized Communities through Social Technology*"

CMU HCII/Philips Health Funder Meeting *10/2019*
"*SleepyGames* Research Presentation" - Co-Presented with Adela Kapuścińska

MOSAIC Annual Conference on Intersectionality, CMU *10/2019*
"*Incorporating Intersectionality in Your Research*" - Co-Facilitated with Judeth Oden Choi

Innovation with Impact, Carnegie Mellon University *04/2019*
"*'They Just Don't Get It': Support Seeking for Racist Experiences*"

Stanford University HCI Group Lunch Seminar *07/2018*
"*Supporting Curiosity-Driven Question-Asking with a Transformational Game*"

In Media Res, Theme Week: Transformative Games *04/2017*
"*Tandem Transformational Game Design*"

Innovation with Impact, Carnegie Mellon University *04/2017*
"*Treehouse Dreams: A Game-Based Method for Eliciting Interview Data from Children*"

Research & Scholarship: Grants

EXTERNAL (Total Funded: $740k)

Funded, Active

1. **NSF CAREER** for "*CAREER: Theory-driven methods for designing more representative, inclusive interactive narratives*" for **$725k** (direct costs: $468k)
   Role: PI (sole, 100% effort). Period: May 2024 - April 2029

Funded, Completed

1. **SIGCHI Development Fund Grant** for "Engaging in Race in HCI" for **$15k**
   Period: May 2020

INTERNAL (Total Funded: $121k)

Funded, Completed

4. **Tier-1 Northeastern University FY24** for "*Transforming Education for BIPOC youth with Game Design and Ecological Justice*" for **$50k**.
   Role: Co-PI with Cliff Lee
   Period: July 2023 - May 2024.
3. **Faculty Innovations Grant in Diversity and Academic Excellence** for "*The Conversation Game: Training students in Residence Life roles to respond to difficult conversations* " for **$11k**.
   Role: Co-PI with Michael Arnold Mages.
   Period: Sept 2021 - Aug 2022.

2. **Tier-1 Northeastern University FY22** for "*Visualizing Spatial Violence (VSV): Tools for Social Justice Advocacy*" for **$50k**.
   Role: Co-PI with Angel David Nieves, Liza Weinstein, Margaret Burnham.
   Period: July 2021 - Sept 2022.
1. **Khoury College Teaching Innovation Grant** for "*Can Team-based Learning Support Remote Indigenous Groups in Computer Science?*" for **$10k**.
   Role: Co-PI with Bethany Edmunds, Logan Schmidt, Yvonne Coady, Derek Jacoby.
   Period: June 2021 - Sept 2021.

Teaching Experience

Rapid Idea Prototyping for Games (GAME 3700)
Art + Design at Northeastern University *2021, 2025*
2021 Fall (12 students), 2025 Fall (6 students)

Mixed Research Methods for Games (GSND 5130)
Art + Design at Northeastern University *2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025*
2021 Fall (17 students), 2022 Fall (17 students), 2023 Fall (8 students),
2024 Fall (16 students), 2025 Fall (18 students)

Computer/Human Interaction (CS 5340)
Khoury College of Computer Sciences at Northeastern University *2025*
2025 Spring (44 students)

Applied Game Design (GSND 6225)*
Art + Design at Northeastern University *2024*
2024 Fall (14 students)
**New course I co-developed on transformational games*

Human-Computer Interaction (IS 4300)
Khoury College of Computer Sciences at Northeastern University *2020, 2024*
2020 Fall (16 students), 2024 Spring (53 students)

Human-Computer Interaction (IS 4300) & Computer/Human Interaction (CS 5340)**
Khoury College of Computer Sciences at Northeastern University *2023*
2023 Spring (102 students) - ***Joint grad/undergrad section*

Introduction to Transformational Games Elective
SMASH Academy at Northeastern University *2022, 2023*
2-week elective,
2022 Summer (20 students): Co-Designed with Lead Instructor Doxa Asibey,
2023 Summer (8 students): Co-Taught w/ Cliff Lee and Jailyn Zabala

Game Concept Dev. and Prod. (GAME 3800)
Art + Design at Northeastern University *2021*
2021 Spring (6 students)

TA, User-Centered Research & Evaluation (05-410/05-610)
Human-Computer Interaction Institute at Carnegie Mellon University *2019*
Instructors of Record: Amy Ogan and Raelin Musuraca

TA, Programming Usable Interfaces (05-430/05630)
Human-Computer Interaction Institute at Carnegie Mellon University *2017*
Instructor of Record: Jason Hong

TA, Navigating Race and Identity in America (85-357)
Psychology Department at Carnegie Mellon University *2017*
Instructor of Record: Kody Manke

TA, Minds and Machines (SymSys 100)

Symbolic Systems Program at Stanford University *2014*

Instructors of Record: Dan Lassiter, Thomas Icard, Todd Davies

CA, Human-Computer Interaction Seminar (CS 547)

Computer Science Department at Stanford University *2014*

Instructor of Record: Michael Bernstein

Advising & Mentorship

POSTDOCS - Mentoring (1)

Current **Yuxi Wu**, Khoury Distinguished Postdoctoral Fellow, Northeastern University

SUPERVISION OF GRADUATE STUDENTS - PhD Advising (6)

Current **Jessica Teurn**, Computer Science, Northeastern University, *Co-Advised with Keith Bagley*

Current **Bethany Miatta Turay**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

Current **Gianna Williams**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

Current **Jailyn Zabala**, Interdisciplinary Design and Media, Northeastern University

2025 **Dilruba Showkat**, Computer Science, Northeastern University
Thesis: "*Towards Algorithmic Reform: Ethical Values-Informed Tool Design and Inclusive AI/ML...*"

2021-2023 **Shereen Bellamy**, Computer Science *[incomplete], Northeastern University*

SUPERVISION OF GRADUATE STUDENTS - PhD Committee (5)

Current **Erika Melder**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

Current **Feifei Chen**, Interdisciplinary Design and Media, Northeastern University

Current **Kutub Gandhi**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

2025 **Nathan Partlan**, Computer Science, Northeastern University
Thesis: "*Computational Creativity Support Tools for Game Behavior Design*"

2023 **Hillary Carey**, Transition Design, Carnegie Mellon University
Thesis: "*Social Design Dreaming: Designing Future Visions of Racial Justice*"

SUPERVISION OF GRADUATE STUDENTS - Masters Theses (3)

2025 **Kexin (Cathy) Zhang**, MFA Experience Design, Northeastern University
Thesis: "*Balancing Engagement and Addiction in Gacha Games: An Experience Design Approach*"

2022 **Jahaan Saini**, MS Human Factors, Northeastern University
Thesis: "*Equitable and Inclusive Product Development*"

2022 **Doxa Asibey**, MS Computer Science, Northeastern University
Thesis: "*They Didn't Mean That: Interactive Fiction for Teaching about Microaggressions*"

SUPERVISION OF GRADUATE STUDENTS - Research Assistants (12)

2024-2025 **Soni Rusagara**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

2024-2025 **Dexter Delandro**, Game Science and Design, Northeastern University

2023 **Audrey Lehrer**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

2022-2023 **Josie Zvelebilova**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

2022 **Shipra Chirag Shah**, Experience Design, Northeastern University

2022 **Rafal Smietana**, Game Science and Design, Northeastern University

2022 **Srinivas Teja Bhattar**, Game Science and Design, Northeastern University

2022 **Jahaan Saini**, Human Factors, Northeastern University

2021-2022 **Devina Raithatha**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

2021-2023 **Doxa Asibey**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

2021 **Xinyu Hou**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

2021 **Heng Su**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

SUPERVISION OF UNDERGRADUATE STUDENTS - Theses & Capstones (1)

2024 **Natalie Chen**, B.S. in Politics, Philosophy, and Economics, Minor in Experience Design
Senior Capstone: "*BIPOC Resistance Through Self-Expression: How BIPOC Leverage Online and Offline Strategies to Oppose Whiteness and Westernness in Internet Culture*"

SUPERVISION OF UNDERGRADUATE STUDENTS - Research Assistants (8)

2024-2025 **Dylan Dinio**, Computer Science and Game Development, Northeastern University
2022-2024 **Natalie Chen**, Politics, Philosophy, and Economics, Northeastern University
2023-2024 **Aleena Narula**, Graphic/Information Design and Communication Studies, Northeastern University
2022-2023 **Laveda Chan**, Cell and Molecular Biology, Northeastern University
2022-2023 **Lingqing Wang**, Industrial Engineering, Tsinghua University
2022 **Maeve Singer**, Computer and Environmental Science, Northeastern University
2021 **Jamie Camera**, BFA CS and Game Dev, Northeastern University
2020-2023 **Chris Brooks**, Computer Science, Northeastern University

FORMAL MENTORING PROGRAMS

2022 **Distributed REsearch Apprenticeships for Master's (DREAM)**, NSF
2021-2022 **Trans/Queer in HCI 1-1 Mentoring Program**, Queer in HCI SIG

Service

Service to the Institution - Northeastern University

2024-2025 **[Dept. Art+Design]** Teaching & Learning Committee,
[Dept. Art+Design] Game Science and Design (GSND) Masters Program Committee,
[College - CAMD] Interdisciplinary Design and Media PhD Admissions,
[University] M.S. in Human- Computer Interaction UIP Development

2023-2024 **[Dept. Art+Design]** Game Science and Design (GSND) Masters Program Committee,
[College - Khoury] PhD and Postdoc Mentoring Committee,
[College - Khoury] Hiring Candidate Host,
[College - Khoury] Evaluating PhD Course Waivers,
[University] Women of Color in the Academy (WoCiA) Conference Planning Committee

2022-2023 **[Dept. Art+Design]** Hiring Committee Member - Art + Design Department Chair Search,
[Dept. Art+Design] Weekly Game Group Meetings,
[Dept. Art+Design] Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Belonging (DEIB) Committee,
[Dept. Art+Design] Game Science and Design (GSND) Masters Program Committee,
[College - CAMD] Hiring Committee Chair - "Extraordinary HCI" CAMD Search,
[College - Khoury] SMASH Northeastern Elective Instruction,
[University] Women of Color in the Academy (WoCiA) Conference Planning Committee,
[University] Tier-1 Grant Proposal Review

2021-2022 **[Dept. Art+Design]** Graduate Lecture Series Co-Coordinator,
[Dept. Art+Design] Bi-Weekly Game Group Meetings,
[Dept. Art+Design] Games@Northeastern Lecture Series Co-Coordinator,
[College - Khoury] CS PhD Admissions Committee,
[College - Khoury] Working Group - Leading with Societal Impact,
[College - Khoury] Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, Accessibility, and Belonging (DEIAB) Committee,
[University] Women of Color in the Academy (WoCiA) Conference Planning Committee

2020-2021 **[Dept. Art+Design]** Diversity, Equity, Inclusion & Belonging (DEIB) Ad Hoc Committee,
[Dept. Art+Design] Game Science and Design (GSND) Masters Program Committee,
[Dept. Art+Design] Bi-Weekly Game Group Meetings,
[College - CAMD] Hiring Committee - Joint CAMD + Khoury Faculty Search Member,
[University] Women of Color in the Academy (WoCiA) Conference Planning Committee

Service to the Discipline/Profession

Co-Chair ACM CHI Play 2022 Masterclass

Subcommittee Chair ACM DIS 2026 "Critical Computing and Design Theory" Track,
ACM DIS 2024 "Critical Computing and Design Theory" Track,
NorthEast HCI Meet-Up 2024 Doctoral Consortium

Associate Chair ACM CHI 2025 "Critical Computing, Sustainability, and Social Justice" Subcommittee,
ACM CHI 2024 "Critical Computing, Sustainability, and Social Justice" Subcommittee,
ACM CHI Play 2023,
ACM DIS 2023,
ACM CHI Play 2022,
ACM CHI 2022 "Games and Play" Subcommittee,
ACM CSCW 2021 (Oct 2020, Jan 2021, Apr 2021, Jul 2021 Cycles)

Program Committee Meaningful Play 2022,
DiGRA 2020 "Game History and Cultural Context" Track,
DiGRA 2019 "Making Sense of Play and Players" Track,
DiGRA 2018 "Users" Track

Conference Session Chair

ACM CHI PLAY:	2025
ACM DIS:	2023, 2024
ACM FDG:	2024
ACM CHI:	2021

LBW/WiP Associate Chair

ACM CHI:	*2021, 2022*
ACM CHI Play:	*2019, 2020*

Grant Proposal Reviewer NSF EDU 2024

Book Manuscripts Reviewed MIT Press 2023, Vernon Press 2025

Book Proposals Reviewed Palgrave Macmillan 2021, MIT Press 2022

Paper Reviewer

ACM CHI:	*2018*, 2020, 2021*, 2023, 2024**, 2025 2026*
ACM CSCW:	*2020*, 2021*, 2022, 2023*
ACM CHI PLAY:	*2020, 2023*
ACM DIS:	*2020, 2021**
ACM IDC:	*2019, 2020*
ACM Creativity & Cognition:	*2017*
ACM UIST:	*2024*

**Special Recognition for Outstanding Review*

IEEE Transactions on Games:	2023
Meaningful Play:	*2018, 2024*
DiGRA/FDG:	*2016*
Storyworlds: A Journal of Narrative Studies:	*2025*
Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society:	*2024*
HICSS:	*2026*

LBW/WiP Reviewer ACM CHI: *2019, 2020, 2023, 2025*
ACM FDG: *2021*
ACM alt.CHI: *2020*
ACM CHI PLAY: *2017*
MobileHCI: *2017*
ACM Creativity & Cognition: *2019*

Student Game Reviewer ACM CHI: *2016, 2020*
Pictorial Reviewer ACM Creativity & Cognition: *2022*
ACM IDC: *2023*

Student Volunteer ACM CHI PLAY 2016, DiGRA 2017

Service to the Community/Public

Selection Committee Carnegie Science Awards 2018, 2019, 2020
Logistics Committee Pittsburgh Racial Justice Summit 2019 (*Signs, Logistics, Accessibility Co-Chair*), Pittsburgh Racial Justice Summit 2020 (*Evaluations Chair*)
Alumni Volunteer Interviewer Stanford University Undergraduate Admissions 2019, 2020
Presenter Pittsburgh Racial Justice Summit 2021, 2022

Professional Development

2025 Khoury NSF CAREER Club Mentor
2024 Khoury NSF CAREER Club Mentor
2023 Khoury NSF CAREER Club Mentee,
CAMD Summer Grant Writing Fellowship
2022 Khoury NSF CAREER Club Mentee,
National Center for Faculty Development & Diversity - Faculty Success Program

Memberships & Affiliations

Northeastern University Mills Institute Faculty Affiliate

Association of Computing Machines (ACM)

ACM Special Interest Group on Computer-Human Interaction (SIGCHI)

American Association of University Professors (AAUP)

Skills & Methods

Research Methods Interviewing, Grounded Theory, Controlled Lab Experiments, Think Aloud Study Protocols, Studies with Children, Ethnomethodology, Surveys, Research Through Design, Co-Design, Thematic Analysis, Intersectional Qualitative Research

User-Centered Design Paper Prototyping, Rapid Iterative Prototyping, UI Wireframing, Heuristic Evaluation, Storyboards, Cognitive Task Analysis, Transformational Game Design, Competitive Analysis, Contextual Inquiry, Diary Studies, Critical Design

Game Design Transformational, Educational, Tabletop, Interactive Narrative (e.g., Inform, Twine), Playtesting, Participatory Design with Children

Selected Media

11/2025 **Khoury News**, Research that hits home: Alexandra To on how diversity fuels creativity in video game design

04/2025 **Northeastern Global News**, The 'Minecraft' movie is a box office smash. An expert explains why that's good for gamers – and parents

12/2024 **Northeastern Global News**, Why are axolotls suddenly so popular — and going extinct at the same time?

08/2024 **Northeastern Global News**, Queer tabletop roleplaying games provide valuable lessons that even 'Dungeons & Dragons' can learn from, new research finds

07/2024 **JFS Podcast**, Episode 1: Barriers to LongTerm Visioning in Racial Justice Work

06/2024 **Northeastern Global News**, Northeastern computer scientist receives prestigious early-career award for game design research

05/2024 **Khoury News**, At Regional HCI Conference, Mentorship and Social Responsibility Take the Stage

05/2024 **Admixing Alexandra's Get Real Podcast**, Episode 11 with Alexandra To

04/2023 **Khoury News**, Awards, ethics, cross-college collaboration: Northeastern at CHI 2023

09/2021 **Khoury News**, Applied learning and real-world problem-solving at the Summer Faculty Research Showcase

11/2020 **Khoury News**, New faculty member A. To designs social technologies for coping with racism

06/2020 **UMSI News**, U-M research reveals racism challenges in human-computer interaction

01/2019 **CMU News**, Alumnus, Students Join Pittsburgh Community at Racial Justice Summit

07/2017 **New York Times**, The Pop-Up Employer: Build a Team, Do the Job, Say Goodbye

11/2016 **HCII News & Events**, HCII & ETC Student Game Brings Home Best Student Game and People's Choice Award

08/2014 **Stanford News**, Stanford's Symbolic Systems program bridges the gap b/t humanity and technology

08/2014 **Stanford News**, Stanford team looks to take crowdsourcing to a whole new level